

Archive Mailbox Full — Troubleshooting Guide

Reference Type: Internal Knowledge Base / General Procedure

1. Issue Summary

A user's archive mailbox reached its storage quota, generating a system notification that no further items could be moved into the archive. The Microsoft 365 admin center's overall storage indicator did not reflect this, since it reports primary mailbox usage separately from archive mailbox usage.

2. Symptom

The following type of notification is generated when an archive mailbox is full:

```
"Your archive mailbox is full."
```

```
"[used amount] used of [quota amount]"
```

```
"You can no longer move messages to your archive mailbox. To make room in your archive mailbox, delete any items you don't need and empty your Deleted Items folder."
```

3. Diagnosis Steps

Because the admin center summary view can understate the problem, verify directly in Exchange Online PowerShell:

```
Get-Mailbox <user> | FL DisplayName, ArchiveGuid, ArchiveQuota, ArchiveWarningQuota, AutoExpandingArchiveEnabled, LitigationHoldEnabled, InPlaceHolds
```

```
Get-MailboxStatistics -Identity <user> -Archive | FL DisplayName, TotalItemSize, ItemCount
```

Sample output confirming a genuinely full archive (identifying details redacted):

```
PS C:\WINDOWS\system32> Get-Mailbox | FL DisplayName, ArchiveGuid, ArchiveQuota, ArchiveWarningQuota, AutoExpandingArchiveEnabled, LitigationHoldEnabled, InPlaceHolds
DisplayName           : 
ArchiveGuid           : 44621bfa-c573-45ac-9cd8-e512491e0ec1
ArchiveQuota          : 50 GB (53,687,091,200 bytes)
ArchiveWarningQuota   : 45 GB (48,318,382,880 bytes)
AutoExpandingArchiveEnabled : False
LitigationHoldEnabled : False
InPlaceHolds          : {}

PS C:\WINDOWS\system32> Get-MailboxStatistics -Identity -Archive | FL DisplayName, TotalItemSize, ItemCount
DisplayName           : In-Place Archive -Artem Kobzev
TotalItemSize         : 50.01 GB (53,694,373,100 bytes)
ItemCount             : 127318

PS C:\WINDOWS\system32> Get-MailboxStatistics -Identity -Archive | FL DisplayName, TotalItemSize, ItemCount
DisplayName           : In-Place Archive -Artem Kobzev
TotalItemSize         : 50.01 GB (53,694,373,100 bytes)
ItemCount             : 127318
```

Key things to check in the output: whether ArchiveQuota is already at capacity, whether AutoExpandingArchiveEnabled is True or False, and whether the mailbox is on any form of hold — a hold changes how Recoverable Items storage is calculated and can be an independent contributing factor.

4. Typical Root Cause

Archive mailbox size limits are tied to the license assigned to the mailbox. Entry-level business plans provide a fixed archive quota with no automatic growth. Auto-expanding archiving is never enabled by default on any license tier — it requires both a license that supports the feature and an administrator to explicitly enable it per mailbox via PowerShell. If neither condition is met, the archive simply stops accepting new items once its fixed quota is reached.

5. Resolution Options

Option	What It Does	Considerations
Add an archiving add-on license	Unlocks auto-expanding archive storage on the existing mailbox.	Requires license assignment, then Enable-Mailbox -AutoExpandingArchive.
Upgrade to a higher license tier	Includes auto-expanding archiving natively, along with other broader features.	Higher cost, broader changes than strictly needed to fix this issue.
Apply a retention / deletion policy	Automatically removes archived items older than a defined age.	Requires sign-off from compliance/legal, if applicable.

6. General Recommendation

Adding an archiving add-on license is typically the most direct fix — it resolves the storage limitation without requiring a compliance review or a broader plan change. Retention/deletion policies are better suited as a longer-term storage management measure once appropriate sign-off has been obtained, particularly in environments where mailbox content may be confidential or subject to retention requirements.

7. General Next Steps

- Confirm the mailbox's current license and whether it supports auto-expanding archiving.
- Assign an archiving add-on license, or upgrade the plan, as appropriate.
- Run `Enable-Mailbox <user> -AutoExpandingArchive`.
- Advise the user that additional storage may take up to 30 days to provision.
- Recheck archive size after provisioning to confirm growth beyond the original quota.